Practical 9

SPECIMEN COLLECTION

A specimen may be defined as a small quantity of a substance or object which shows the kind and quality of the whole (sample).

Specimen collection defined as the collection of the specimen for the purposes of diagnosis, treatment and recovery.

Preparation of the clients

- Explain the procedure to the patient. It helps to gain the client's trust and cooperation.
- When preparing the client the nurse's explanation should be clear, straight forward and complete.
- Some test requires more detailed instruction to promote cooperation and ensure accurate specimen collections especially when the client has to modify his behavior before the test and when he will be collecting the specimen himself.
- Be sure that the client has understood clearly and correctly the information.
- Proper understanding of the procedure will help to gain informed consent.
- Provide a appropriate container and explain how to use it.
- In case of collection of urine, instruct the client to wash the genitalia with soap and water, then rinse it in water before collecting the specimen.
- Instruct the client not to contaminate the outside of the bottle.
- Instructions to use gloves and other barriers as necessary.

Preparation of the equipment

- All specimens are collected in clean and dry containers.
- Use containers with wide mouth.
- Sterile containers are used for culture.
- Wax lined disposable cups are used for sputum and stool specimens.
- Large containers are used for 24 hours urine specimens.
- Sterile test tubes are used to collect fluids.
- Clean slides are used to collect smears.
- No antiseptic solution must be present in the specimen bottle as they may hamper the growth of micro organism and thus obscure the results.

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